# MAKGADIKGADI PANS HERITAGE TRAIL



*Sunset at Baines Baobabs. 2012*

## Introduction

Makgadikgadi Pans Heritage Trail links pristine culutural and nature heritage sites found on the remains of one of the largest palaeolakes in the world. Its unique attractions include Ntwetwe, Sua, Nxai and Kudiakam pans; Nxghaishini fossils, Boteti River, Lake Xau, Nxai Pan National Park and Makgadikgadi Pans National Park. These heritage sites are symbolic of formation processes of the Makgadikgadi Pans and cultures that developd here since time immemorial. A complete tour of this unique heritage trail provides unparralleled experiences of animals, plants and scenic mining "hills" of Orapa, Damtshaa and Letlhakane mines. Furthermore, the trail is home to the legendary Baines, Chapman and Greenes Baobas which still stand guard of a historic road used by early travellers heading into the interiors of Southern Africa.

## LIST of ALL SITES

▢NATURAL & ▢CULTURAL Sites

**South Sua Trail**
1. Unikae Spring
2. Mmakgama Ruins
3. Kaitshe Escarpment
4. Mosu Escarpment
5. Tlapana Ruins
6. Toragara
7. Makgaba Fossils

**Lekhubu Trail**
8. Lekhubu Island
9. Thitaba Ruins
10. Orapa Game Park
21. Nata Bird Sanctuary
22. Soda Ash Mine
23. Sua Pan
24. Ntwetwe Pan

**Boteti River Trail**
11. Xanikaga Fossils
12. Lake Xau
13. Kwalabe Footprints
14. Boteti River
25. Mokgalo wa ga Kgama

**Baobabs Trail**
15. Makgadikgadi Pans National Park
16. Baines Baobabs
17. Nxai Pan National Park
18. Greenes Baobab
19. Chapmans Baobab
20. Nxghaishini Pan


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## Accommodation

- H1 **Boteti Hotel** Tel (+267) 297 8289
- H2 **Mikelele Motel** Tel (+267) 297 8594
- H3 **Granny's Kitchen** Tel (+267) 297 8246
- H4 **Seolo Hotel** Tel (+267) 290 2922
- H5 **Xere Motel** Tel (+267) 297 5068 Cell (+267) 7172 3907
- H6 **Planet Baobab** Tel (+267) 240 3309 Cell (+267) 7233 8344
- H7 **Gweta Lodge** Tel (+267) 621 2220
- H8 **Jacks Camp** Tel (+267) 240 3309
- H9 **North Gate Lodge** Tel (+267) 621 1155 / 621 1156
- H10 **Nata Lodge** Tel (+267) 621 1260 / 621 1210
- H11 **Pelican Lodge** Tel (+267) 2470117
- H12 **Makgadikgadi Lodge** Tel (+267) 621 3197 / 621 3713
- H13 **Moriti wa Selemo** Tel (+267) 737 774 28

# MAKGADIKGADI PANS Heritage Trail Map




### 1 Unikae Spring

Unikae Spring is one of the few perennial springs found around. This spring is located 1 km east of Mosu Primary School in a scenic valley at S21° 12' 36.3" E 26°01' 35.5". Although found in a generally salty area, this spring is a reliable source of fresh water. People around Mosu use this spring for watering domestic animals. Some religious groups believe this water is sacred.



### 2 Mmakgama Ruins

Mmakgama ruins is a cultural heritage site located about 7 km west of Mosu at S 21° 12' 18.1" E 25° 59'25.0. The site is characterised by a coursed stone enclosure built during the Great Zimbabwe period. These ruins were built during the 14th century as an extension of the Great Zimbabwe empire into the Makgadikgadi pans region. The occupants of Mmakgama traded glass beads with the local Khoesan people for salt and furs.



### 3 Kaitshe Escarpment

Kaitshe is a multi cultural site located on a promontory escarpment overlooking the southern most edges of Sowa Pan. It is located some 15 km to the northeast of Mosu at S 21° 13' 27.8". E 26° 10' 03.8". There are free standing stone walls built around AD 1000 by Leopards Kopje farmers. Large middens with scatters of stone tools, animal bones, iron tools, glass beads and pottery fragments suggest that people lived here for a long time.



### 4 Mosu Escarpment

This monument is one of the hilltop Iron Age villages found around Mosu. This site is located 1 km south of Makgadikgadi Secondary School. Early farmers living here preferred settling on the edges of the escarpment overlooking the picturesque Sua Pan. It was occupied extensively between AD 800 - AD 1300 by farming people known archaeologically as Zhizo and Leopard Kopje. These farmers grew crops on the sandveld plateau to the south of their villages. They kept cattle, goats and hunted wild animals for meat.





*Sunrise at Lekhubu Island. 2012*

# NATURAL & CULTURAL Sites

All the Photos by Ryuichi Ishida (Japan International Cooperation Agency)

## 5 Tlapana Ruins

Tlapana Ruins were built sometime between AD 1100 and 1200. The site is located 5 km south west of Mmeya on an isolated and picturesque ridge overlooking Mosope River and the southeastern corner of Sua Pan at S 21˚ 07' 35.0" E 26˚ 17' 24.3". These ruins were probably built by Leopards Kopje farmers who lived in this area trading salt glass beads for salt and furs with Khoesan people living around the pans.



## 8 Lekhubu Island

This is undoubtedly the wonder of the Makgakgadikgadi Pans. Its unique location attracted humans for time immemorial. It is located at S 20˚ 53' 24.8" E 25˚ 49' 46.6". Ancient ruins found here are recorded as the Lost City of the Kalahari by early travellers who were impressed by this magnificent island.





## 11 Xanikaga Fossils

This natural site documents rare evidence of dessication of palaeo lake Makgadikgadi Pans over 20 000 years ago. It is located at S 21˚ 11' 22.0" E 25˚ 03' 54 .9". At this site, print of animals that came to drink in the receding waters of the lake apparently were permanently marked in the mud that later on solidified here. Bones of animals and antelope prints are visible in the calcrete matrix. These fossil remains are important as they can help in the reconstruction of the climate of the Makgadikgadi region over 20 000 years ago.



## 15 Makgadikgadi Pans National Park

Makgadikgadi Pans National Park is located 160 km east of Maun and 45 km west of Gweta. The park is about 3 900 square kilometres in size. During the wet season over 10 000 herds of big game such as wildbeest, zebra and springbok water here. During the dry season huge herds of zebra and wildbeest migrate northwards to Nxai Pan and beyond, creating the second largest migration of wildlife in Sub Saharan Africa.



## 18 Greenes Baobab

Greenes Baobab is a National Monument found along the historic road to the north used by 19th and 20th century explorers, traders and hunters travelling to the interiors of the country to destinations such as Lake Ngami and further on to Victoria Falls. This baobab was made famous by an expedition led by the Greene brothers who camped here during the late 1880's. An inscription of their names together with many other historic travelers who passed here is found on the trunk of this magnificent baobab.





## 21 Nata Bird Sanctuary

Nata Bird Sanctuary is one of the best places from where to view the Makgadikgadi Pans. The sanctuary has a massive viewing deck ensuring the most amazing vantage points. This is an astonishing place to stop and view the wildlife when you are on your Botswana Safari. It is also an important conservational project and therefore visiting this sanctuary helps to support the cause.



## 22 Soda Ash Mine

This mine is located at Sua Pan which is approximately 180 kilometres from Francistown. The company produces soda ash and salt. It was established in 1991 at a cost of P736 million, with an additional P100 million invested in infrastructural development of Sowa township. All the activities of the soda ash mining are undertaken here. The mine produces 300 000 tonnes of soda ash per annum.



## 6 Toragaraa

These unique features are found on the north eastern edges of Mmea Pan. The site is located 3 km south of Mmea village at S 21˚ 06' 42.1" E 26˚ 19' 58.9". The formation of these features is not geologically recorded in the Sua Pan. Local communities around Mmeya call these features *toragaraa*, a Sesarwa name which literally means dishes of the ancestors. The location of these features in pans and their seemingly perfect circular shapes adds to the mystery of Toragaraa.



## 9 Thitaba Ruins

Thitaba Ruins is the largest stone walled site in the Makgadikgadi pans. The site was built around AD 1100 by Leopards Kopje people. It is located at S 20˚ 48' 01.3" E25˚ 42'11.7", some 17 km west of Lekhubu near Tshwagong on a ridge of basement rock running parallel to the eastern shore of Ntwetwe Pan. Within an enclosure measuring 300 x 300 metres, house foundations, granary bins, middens and kraals can be found. Thitaba Ruins are considered sacred by the local Shua - Khoe people who call the ruins a kraal of ancestors.



## 12 Lake Xau

After 40 years of complete dryness, Lake Xau is full again after being fed with waters coming down the Boteti River. It has quickly transformed from an ugly dust bowl to its glorious years of tourist attraction. This lake is located at S 21˚ 21' 09.3" E 24 43' 38.3"



## 13 Kwalabe Footprints

Kwalabe Footprints are part of the legendary Matsieng type rock engravings found in most parts of southern Botswana. It is located at S21˚ 23' 05.3" E 24˚ 38' 57.0". Kwalabe is believed to be a giant who stepped in this area while rocks were still wet. Legend has it that he was farmer herding goats in the Boteti area.



## 16 Baines Baobabs

Baines Baobabs are one of the most famous baobabs in Botswana. These trees form a unique cluster growing on the northeastern edges of Kudiakam Pan. They were made famous by a renowned British explorer and artist known as Thomas Baines. This explorer painted and publicised them in the 1860s. The painting popularized these baobabs and resulted in many explorations to these trees. Ever since the time they were immortalized by Thomas Baines painting, these baobabs have not changed. Today Baines Baobabs are a famous destination for tourists visiting Nxai Pan National Park and are located at S 20˚ 06' 44.7" E 24˚ 46' 08.7"



## 19 Chapmans Baobab

This massive and multi-trunked baobab is a National Monument gazetted in 2006. It is named after a historic explorer and traveller named James Chapman who passed through the edges of the Ntwetwe Pan sometimes during the late 1870s. The baobab is a historic landmark located along the road to the north used by explorers, travelers and hunters and is located at S 20˚ 29' 24.5" E 25˚ 14' 58.2". The unique shape of the baobab has earned this monument several names such as Xaugam, a Sesarwa name meaning a lion's tail.



## 23 Sua Pan

The Sua Pan is one of three large pans within the Makgadikgadi, the other two being Nxai Pan and Nwetwe Pan. Sua Pan was first described to the European world by David Livingstone after his famous exploration to Lake Ngami.



## 7 Makgaba Fossils

These rare fossil trees are found 12 km south west of Mokubilo at S 21˚ 16' 30.9" E 26˚ 17' 45.8" near a scenic spring known as Simanentshaa. Although the exact date of these fossil trees is not yet known, it is believed that they were probably formed over 50 million years ago. These trees were fossilised during volcanic activities that took place in the area leading to extinction of many plants and formation of diamondiferous kinberlites around Orapa. Makgaba fossils are one of the few sites in Botswana where fossilised wood remains are found in a good condition.



## 10 Orapa Game Park

Orapa Game Park was formed from a core conservation area developed from a degraded cattle grazing zone and recreational area around Orapa Mine in 1985. Over the years, the park has developed and icreased in size from 3000 hectares in 1992 to its current size of 10 800 hectares. Orapa Game Park is home to black rhino, white rhino, zebra, eland, wildbeest, springbok, giraffe and waterbuck.



## 14 Boteti River

Boteti River derives its main waters from the core of the Okavango Delta through the Thamalakane River. This river crosses the Maun - Letlhakane road into Lake Xau at S 21˚ 07' 06.5" E 24˚ 38' 34.9". During the flooding season, the Boteti River discharges its waters into the Makgadikgadi Pans area. The flow of the Boteti River in 2010 after 20 years resuscitated biologibal diversity.



## 17 Nxai Pan National Park

Nxai Pan National Park is adjacent to the Makgadikgadi Pans National Park and is approximately 2,578 km$^2$ in size. Visitors are able to self-drive into the park, however only 4x4 vehicles should attempt the journey. The area was initially government land and was declared a game reserve in 1970. The highlight of the Nxai Pan is the water hole, situated in the centre of the park in a large grassy plain.



## 20 Nxghaishini Pan

Ngxhaishini is located about 15 km north of Gweta at S 20˚ 04' 58.7" E 25˚ 22' 20.0". To this day, it is the only documented site in Botswana with Early Stone Age, Middle Stone Age and Late Stone Age tools, stone hunting blinds and faunal remains. This pan has been an important drinking hole of animals for over 1 million years. Hunting blinds found in the site testify to this. Stone Age people used hand axes found on the pan to butcher wild animals that came to drink here. They dismembered animal carcasses here and left the bones in the site exposed to fossilisation over long periods of time.



## 24 Ntwetwe Pan

Ntwetwe Pan is the western twin of Sua. It is of a similar size and general topography, though aligned more east-west. The old north–south trading route used by travellers between Gweta and Mopipi crosses the centre of Ntwetwe Pan.



## 25 Mokgalo wa ga Kgama

The historic tree details the separation of the Batawana people and Bangwato at around 1800. Oral traditions suggest that the Batawana are the people of Tawana who led them from the Shoshong Hills to the Kgwebe Hills near Lake Ngami in about 1790. The Batawana originally sprung from the Bakwena who in their turn had their origins in the Bahurutshe who are really the fountain head of all Setswana speaking tribe.

